SYMPOSIUM ON BEST PRACTICES IN HUMANITARIAN INFORMATION EXCHANGE

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F I N A L R E P O R T

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FOREWORD

It is my pleasure to present to you the final report on the Symposium on Best Practices in Humanitarian Information Exchange.

This report comes at a time when the field of humanitarian information has come of age. Just five years ago, humanitarian information projects were new and unproven, time-critical documents, such as situation reports, press releases and flash appeals were still distributed by fax, telex and cable, the potential uses of Internet technologies and the World Wide Web by the humanitarian community was little understood.

Today, information initiatives are some of the most imaginative and dynamic in the humanitarian field. Global information services such as ReliefWeb and IRIN have revolutionized the way information is disseminated to the wider humanitarian community; humanitarian information centres (HIC) have improved methods for sharing operational data on the ground; rich databases and powerful GIS mapping tools have helped us prioritize our actions and assess the impact of our work; and Web sites, hosted by both developed and developing countries, have allowed humanitarian organisations to raise awareness of humanitarian issues and promote the interests of those in need. The successes and failures of these projects now offer us a wealth of experience that we can learn from and build upon.

In the past five years, the field of humanitarian information has also reached critical mass in terms of participation. Interest is no longer confined to the technically savvy or technology-rich. Rather, humanitarian information has attracted a mix of information managers, policy makers, technicians and entrepreneurs from UN agencies, governments, NGOs, academia, the media and the private sector. Notable is a growing interest among governments and NGOs from developing countries that recognize the potential for information management and technology to facilitate more effective and timely humanitarian action. I look forward to seeing this participation grow in future activities and events.

Collectively, Symposium participants used this four-day event to take stock of accomplishments, discuss key themes and identify current and future challenges including the uses and users of humanitarian information, the importance of standards and appropriate use of technology and the need for partnerships at all levels and better response from decision-makers and donors. This report is a synthesis of the outcomes of these debates.

From the outset the Symposium was envisioned, not as an academic exercise, but as an opportunity to generate new ideas and produce something tangible, useful and visionary. The resulting Statement on Best Practices for Humanitarian Information Management and Exchange, adopted by participants, captures both the substance and the spirit of the Symposium in a collection of principles, themes, best practices and recommendations that lay the groundwork for future action.

Included in this Statement is a recommendation to define a multi-stakeholder framework, facilitated by OCHA, within which the we can take up the challenges we addressed: how to better tailor information systems and products to strategic and operational needs in the field, how to harness the power of technology without becoming beholden to it and how to broaden participation and investment in information projects and educate those in positions of power on the impact of our work.

As we move forward to implement these recommendations, I look forward to your continued collaboration and support.

Ed Tsui
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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Collecting and sharing timely, reliable and accurate information during a crisis is critical to improving humanitarian response, maximizing resources and minimizing human suffering. The faster humanitarian organisations are able to collect, analyse and disseminate critical information, the more effective the response becomes and the more lives are potentially saved. Though humanitarian information functions, systems and tools have improved in the past five years, a combination of operational, funding and technical constraints, combined with a lack of awareness, continues to handicap information from becoming a core, well-resourced component of relief operations.

It was in this context that the Symposium on Best Practices for Humanitarian Information Exchange convened from 5 – 8 February 2002 in the Palais des Nations in Geneva, Switzerland. Attended by more than 250 information professionals and policy-makers from the broad humanitarian community, the event aimed to document best practices gleaned from past and current information activities, raise awareness about humanitarian information and chart a course for the future. The event began with two days of task team discussions followed by a larger, two-day plenary of panel discussions and concluded with the adoption of a Statement on Best Practices for Humanitarian Information Management and Exchange. (See Part III, Recommendations and Implementation for the full text of the Statement)

A core and common theme was the need for principles. As humanitarian information gains recognition and purpose, it should be guided by a set of humanitarian and operational principles that promote humanitarian objectives and foster trust and accountability among organisations. Participants identified ten operational principles to guide humanitarian information management and exchange including accessibility, inclusiveness, inter-operability, accountability, verifiability, relevance, objectivity, humanity, timeliness and sustainability. Related to this is the development of, and adherence to, procedural, technical and ethical standards for information collection, exchange, security, attribution and use. Using standards allows information managers to better handle the large volumes of data and information generated during a crisis, to ensure the integrity of the data and to avoid having to start from scratch every time an emergency erupts.

To better meet the demands of decision-makers and other stakeholders, information projects should also reduce the effects of information overload and serve both operational and strategic needs of decision-makers at all levels. To achieve this, information managers should identify their target audiences and create high-value products to improve data collection, synthesis and analysis. Participants identified the creation of tools such as the *Who Is Doing What Where* database, the development of standards under the Structured Humanitarian Assistance Reporting (SHARE) and Global Identifier Numbers (GLIDE) initiatives and the application of these standards to geographic information and mapping in Kosovo and Sierra Leone, as some ways to improve operational effectiveness.

Another critical aspect of humanitarian information management and exchange is preparedness. Information flow during a crisis can be crippled by lack of time, few resources, isolated decision-making, limited information sources and sparse communication among actors, making it difficult to gather and process accurate data in a timely way. The preparation of baseline data for high-risk areas, the development of toolkits for the deployment of rapid response HICs and the coordination between international and national partners in the field contribute to a more efficient and effective response. As demonstrated during the February 2000 floods in Mozambique, pre-establishing content, mechanisms and relationships, allowed both national and international information systems to improve the speed and efficiency of the relief efforts and enhance coordination among government and international organisations.

Moreover, cooperation among international organisations, local and national actors, the media the private sector and academia encourage trust and commitment among stakeholders, and allow information systems to remain focused on common rather than narrow interests. Of particular importance are field-level partnerships among agencies, governments and NGOs. Where appropriate, information managers should involve local governments and organisations in planning activities, use local information infrastructure and transfer information management activities to local hands after the disaster has been resolved.

National and local partnerships should also be considered when procuring and applying technology. Even the most robust databases and search engines are useless if few are able to access or use them. Information managers and technicians should therefore refrain from adopting the latest, bleeding-edge technologies in favour of robust, well-tested and cost-effective tools that allow for the broadest possible use and reach, conform to the sophistication of the local infrastructure and allow for appropriate training for technical and non-technical staff.

Finally, participants reiterated that humanitarian information projects are still not adequately funded, by donors. Information managers should raise institutional, donor and media awareness about the importance of humanitarian information, and should include funding requests for information projects and systems in the overall resourcing of assistance programmes.

Recommendations and Implementation
At the conclusion of the Symposium, participants endorsed the Statement on Best Practices in Humanitarian Information Management and Exchange, which recommended further exploration of the issues discussed above. To implement its recommendations, the Statement proposed that a multi-stakeholder steering committee be established to catalogue and evaluate ongoing initiatives, establish working groups to implement recommendations and design an appropriate process to bring these issues to institutional and policy-making levels.

Conclusion
As the field of humanitarian information evolves, senior managers, decision-makers and policy officers working at organisational and strategic levels must ensure that the recommendations identified here are adequately supported to turn what have been ad hoc approaches into institutional imperatives with accepted standards, methodologies and practices.

But perhaps the greatest challenge for this field is creating a culture of information sharing that promotes the systematic collection, use and free flow of data, information and ideas, facilitates informed decision-making and builds trust and commitment among stakeholders.

Because of what’s at stake in humanitarian operations, the consequences of not sharing information are too high to ignore.

INTRODUCTION
Background, Purpose and Structure of the Symposium

The Symposium on Best Practices in Humanitarian Information Exchange took place on 5 – 8 February 2002 in Geneva, Switzerland at the Palais des Nations. It was the largest UN-sponsored conference to deal exclusively with humanitarian information. More than 250 participants – professionals working for the UN humanitarian agencies, non-governmental organisations, several governments, academia and the private sector – attended the plenary event. (See Annex B for a participants list)

The purpose of the Symposium was to document the lessons learned and best practices from past and current information activities, and to chart a course for the future. The event also sought to raise awareness about the wide range of humanitarian information activities and increase appreciation within the United Nations and among its partners of the role of information in humanitarian coordination and operations.

Though few dispute the fact that information is integral to humanitarian action and coordination, information management is often taken for granted by the humanitarian community and it is often difficult to secure the necessary support and investment for information collection, management, analysis and dissemination activities. As UN Deputy Emergency Relief Coordinator Carolyn McAskie said in her keynote speech, "The fact that information management is an essential determinant of the effectiveness of the delivery of humanitarian assistance is still not fully appreciated, nor for that matter funded, by donors."

Information needs to be given priority as a core humanitarian function and resource. Like other humanitarian resources (food aid, potable water, medicine, shelter), humanitarian information should be provided to those who can use it and need it. It should be made available to the local, national, and international organisations providing humanitarian assistance to the affected population of the emergency. It should also be made available to aid recipients to enhance their understanding of who is assisting them and why.

In addition to sharing experiences and advocating humanitarian information activities, the Symposium set out to produce a tangible product – a Statement of Best Practices in Humanitarian Information Management and Exchange, developed and endorsed by the participants – that would identify principles, key issues, lessons learned and best practices and make recommendations for future action.

To achieve this objective, the structure and the topics were designed to challenge assumptions about humanitarian information, facilitate the frank exchange of ideas and experiences, and promote participant buy-in for the statement. To this end, the four-day Symposium was divided into two days of task team discussions followed by a two-day plenary. (See Annex A for the Symposium agenda)

The first two days (5 – 6 February) focused on four task-team discussions that addressed the following issues:

Task Team A: Share best practices in the development of field-based Web sites and make recommendations to strengthen field-based information exchange among humanitarian partners.

Task Team B: Investigate the use of new, emerging technologies and approaches, such as Internet portals, knowledge management gateways, large data and information repositories, search engines, Web-based interactive mapping, etc. to enhance the exchange and retrieval of information.

Task Team C: Review lessons learned and evaluate database applications for field-based, cross-sectoral information coordination.

Task Team D: Review lessons learned and evaluate field-based HICs

Each task team was chaired by an information management practitioner and included an average of 18 members from UN agencies, NGOs, governments, academia and the private sector, selected for their expertise on the task team topic. Two professional facilitators assisted the process by enabling the discussion and keeping the group on track.

Days 1 and 2 allowed each task team to discuss the principles and issues related to their topic, derive lessons learned from past and current experiences, identify best practices for future use, and make recommendations for next steps. In addition, each task team discussed crosscutting issues, such as common principles for humanitarian information, the role of standards and the information needs for strategic and operational decision-making.

The task teams were then merged into two groups to encourage the cross-fertilization of ideas, perspectives and experiences. For example, Task Team A and Task Team D merged to discuss the linkages between the HICs and field-based Web sites.

Each of the task teams then consolidated the outcome of their discussions into a presentation, which they delivered to the plenary conference on Day 3. These presentations followed a common template, outlining themes, principles, lessons learned, best practices and recommendations and became the basis for the Statement of Best Practices in Humanitarian Information Management and Exchange. (See Annex D for notes from these task team presentations)

Days 3 and 4 (7 – 8 February) consisted of a much larger, plenary conference of approximately 250 participants. Day 3 opened with a keynote address from UN Deputy Emergency Relief Coordinator Carolyn McAskie. Edward Girardet, founder of Media Action International, opened the discussions on Day 4. (See Annex C for the full text of these keynote addresses) The plenary agenda was built around four panel discussions. Each four-person panel was led by a moderator and included representatives from UN agencies, NGOs, governments and academia, who had recognised expertise in the panel topic. These panels addressed the following questions:

Panel 1: What has been accomplished in the field of humanitarian information over the last five years and what key challenges remain?

Panel 2: What are the benefits and constraints for organisations to collect and share information in the field and what can be done to promote organisational buy-in to share this information?

Panel 3: How can simple common standards and practices enhance inter-operability of systems and the sharing of information?

Panel 4: How is information used for humanitarian coordination, and strategic and operational decision-making?

Each day, the plenary discussions were consolidated and integrated into a draft of the Statement, which was distributed to select participants for comment.

During the final plenary session, the rapporteur distributed a draft of the Statement to all participants for comment. The Symposium chair then led a drafting session, during which participants accepted or rejected the revisions suggested by their peers. Those accepted were recorded and incorporated into a second version, which was published on the Symposium Web site for additional feedback. The final Statement of Best Practices in Humanitarian Information Management and Exchange was adopted and published on 5 March 2002. (See Annex C for the final Statement)

ISSUES AND THEMES

The benefits of sharing information are clear: In a sudden-onset emergency, the quick assessment of needs, the creation of emergency maps and the matching of needs with available resources at the outbreak of war improves the efficiency and efficacy of response. During protracted conflicts, the ongoing assessment of political, economic and social changes and the dissemination of this information at headquarters and on the ground aims to ensure that planning, funding and assistance stay ahead of events. Over time, better communication, data collection and information management leads to better risk assessment, targeted prevention and more effective preparedness activities.

In the past five years, the use of information in humanitarian operations has come of age. Global information services such as ReliefWeb (www.reliefweb.int), AlertNet (www.alertnet.org) and the Integrated Response Information Network (IRIN) (www.irinnews.org) have revolutionised the way humanitarian information is catalogued and disseminated. Field-based Web sites have brought international, national and local partners together to address the needs of practitioners and local populations. Initiatives such as Structured Humanitarian Assistance Reporting (SHARE) and Global Identifier Numbers (GLIDE) have set down standards for information collection and use. Humanitarian information centres (HICs) in Kosovo, Sierra Leone, Eritrea and Afghanistan have changed the way operational data is packaged and shared at the field level. And recent emergencies in Mozambique, the Democratic Republic of Congo and Afghanistan demonstrate that the timely and accurate processing of data and information can improve coordination in tangible, measurable ways.

Despite this progress, several key challenges remain. Humanitarian organisations often withhold information to maintain competitive advantage, particularly when funding is at stake, to the detriment of the affected population. Even when goodwill does exist among organisations, technical constraints make information inaccessible to those who need it. Though field-based systems have improved operational response, they have been unable to address the needs of decision makers or fully engage national and local actors in the strategic and technical aspects of their work. Finally, donors have yet to appreciate the importance of information in relief operations, and remain shortsighted in their funding of information projects.

Below are some of the issues and themes that Symposium participants identified as critical to overcoming these challenges. The discussion below is not a chronicle of the event, but rather a synthesis of the insights, experiences and best practices shared by the participants both during the task team working groups and the panel discussions of the plenary.

The Need for Principles

As principles of action guide humanitarian relief operations, so should principles of information guide humanitarian information management and exchange.

While the purpose of humanitarian response is to assist affected and at-risk people, the object of information management and exchange should promote more effective humanitarian action. To achieve this, information managers should follow a set of operational principles that both address issues of trust, objectivity and accountability among information partners and ensure the quality and purpose of the data itself.

Inspiring confidence in partners and donors and gaining the trust of the affected population are critical to the success of any information-related activity. This involves not only verifying and confirming the accuracy and identifying the source of data and information, but also ensuring that the source of the information is credible.

Information systems should also resist manipulation by external pressures. Governments, opposition groups or competing aid organisations may use humanitarian information to get media attention to further their own agendas or as a means of influencing donors. Humanitarian information activities should therefore strive to be objective in their presentation and transparent in their analytical methodologies.

Finally, humanitarian information should be useful, accessible and sharable by those who need and use it.

Operational Principles for Humanitarian Information Management and Exchange

Accessibility. Humanitarian information and data should be made accessible to all humanitarian actors by applying easy-to-use formats and by translating information into common or local languages when necessary. Information and data for humanitarian purposes should be made widely available through a variety of online and offline distribution channels including the media.

Inclusiveness. Information management and exchange should be based on a system of collaboration, partnership and sharing with a high degree of participation and ownership by multiple stakeholders, especially representatives of the affected population.

Inter-operability. All sharable data and information should be made available in formats that can be easily retrieved, shared and used by humanitarian organisations.

Accountability. Users must be able to evaluate the reliability and credibility of data and information by knowing its source. Information providers should be responsible to their partners and stakeholders for the content they publish and disseminate.

Verifiability. Information should be accurate, consistent and based on sound methodologies, validated by external sources and analysed within the proper contextual framework.

Relevance. Information should be practical, flexible, responsive, and driven by operational and decision-making needs throughout all phases of a crisis.

Objectivity. Information managers should consult a variety of sources when collecting and analysing information so as to provide varied and balanced perspectives for addressing problems and recommending solutions.

Humanity. Information should never be used to distort, to mislead or cause harm to affected or at-risk populations and should respect the dignity of victims.

Timeliness. Humanitarian information must be kept current and should be collected, analysed and disseminated efficiently.

Sustainability. Humanitarian information and data should be preserved, catalogued and archived so that it can be retrieved for future use, such as for preparedness, analysis, lessons learned and evaluation.

Uses and Users

Information projects should reduce the effects of information overload, serve clearly defined operational needs, support decision-making and address strategic planning at all levels.

To achieve this, information managers should identify their target audiences, understand their needs, develop and distribute high-value products that are practical, flexible, relevant, responsive and timely. In particular, information managers should distinguish between the granular processing of operational data for field purposes and the need for the synthesis and analysis of information by senior managers at headquarters. Information products and services should never duplicate or replace other systems, rather they should add value to what others are doing.

Products such as standardised survey forms, assessments, standard operational procedures, place – or "p" – codes (unique numeric codes that identify geographic locations), geo-spatial analysis and *Who Is Doing What Where (WWW)* databases have been successful at addressing some of the needs of practitioners and improving operational effectiveness in the field. In Kosovo, a WWW database was developed to coordinate the activities of more than 200 government institutions, international agencies and NGOs operating in the region by matching humanitarian needs with assistance activities so that decision-makers could prioritise relief operations.

To improve the flow of relief supplies during disasters, the Pan American Health Organisation (PAHO) has created a supply management database (SUMA) to track unsolicited provisions – medical supplies and pharmaceuticals – donated by individuals, groups and businesses. By inventorying the arrival and tracking the distribution of these supplies, SUMA eases relief distribution networks by allowing aid agencies to incorporate these donations into their planning and relief activities.

Geographic Information Systems (GIS) have also become powerful analytic and common reference instruments when applied to both complex emergencies and natural disasters. For example in Kosovo, GIS specialists applied simple analytical tools and produced layered maps that compared unexploded mine locations to the proximity of footpaths used by children on their way to school. The maps helped determine priority areas for de-mining. In Sierra Leone GIS specialists currently use maps that match needs with relief activities to attract donor interest.

In addition, a number of field-based Web sites have been successful at targeting their content to serve local needs. OCHA's Web site for the Northern Caucuses (www.ocha.ru) publishes local news, situation reports and documents in both English and Russian, while humanitarian sites such as UgandAid (www.ugandaid.net) in Uganda, AzerWeb in Azerbaijan (www.azerweb.com) and Save the Children's *Assistance Georgia* Web site (www.assistancegeorgia.org.ge/), help local government institutions and NGOs share information by hosting and publishing their information and services on its site.

Products such as situation reports and appeals distributed via global information services have been successful at synthesizing operational information and communicating field situations to headquarters. This gives decision-makers at headquarters and in donor organisations an accurate and evolving picture of what is taking place on the ground.

However, an uneven information flow during an emergency makes it difficult to serve the needs of decision-makers. At the core of this issue is information analysis and data collection. On one hand a glut of narrative, non-operational information is overwhelming and therefore useless when it comes to quick decision-making and timely action. On the other hand, data necessary for operational decision-making is not available in the form or level of detail required.

Information systems, particularly HICs, should better reduce the effects of information overload and facilitate data synthesis and analysis by providing experts with technical and mapping support, by applying their knowledge of datasets to better package analysis and by playing a coordinating role in collecting and disseminating this analysis to others. In addition, information systems should secure, streamline and standardise the process of collecting relevant data in a way that allows senior managers to easily grasp the issues and apply the analysis quickly and to good effect.

Best Practices for Developing Data and Information Products

Define user needs and utilise data sets and formats that directly support decision-making at the field and headquarters levels. Identify user groups, conduct user requirement analysis, inventory information resources and define core information products based on user input.

Develop and implement information products on operationally and strategically relevant themes, such as the location and condition of the affected population, "who is doing what, where?" and assessments of needs.

Consult data providers as well as affected populations when designing information products. Without direct feedback to and from the data providers and affected populations, community information collection strategies will fail. The humanitarian community, governments and beneficiaries must be thought of as customers as well as data providers.

Create and disseminate templates for sectoral assessments and analysis, such as the Rapid Village Assessment (RVA) tool or the Microsoft/Save the Children assessment tool for personal digital assistants (PDA), to speed data collection. Create maps and graphic presentations to effectively communicate information to decision-makers.

Participation and Partnerships

No one organisation can collect all of the data and information needed during a relief operation. So cooperation among international organisations, local and national actors, and the media is critical to both the short-term success and long-term sustainability of both global and field-based information systems. Partnerships encourage trust and commitment among stakeholders and allow information systems to remain objective, accountable and focused on common rather than narrow interests.

Global Partnerships

Global information systems are particularly important for building trust and achieving buy-in at an institutional level. These systems have succeeded in building partnerships around data and document repositories and by creating online communities. For example, OneWorld (www.oneworld.net) acts as a "meeting place" for its 1000 partners who can use the site to reach a monthly audience of hundreds of thousands journalists, broadcasters, educators, aid workers and members of the public. ReliefWeb relies on relationships with more than 700 content partners to keep its database of 150,000 documents on more than 40 humanitarian emergencies fresh and balanced. The World Bank's Gateway (www.worldbank.org/gateway) has created a data repository that consolidates statistics from national and international organisations that offer data, or information about data, on their sites. Finally, AlertNet created the Professional Zone, a password-protected area of the site that allows its 172 members to post news, comments and contacts of use to other humanitarian professionals.

Field Partnerships

Information management partnerships at the field level are particularly important for facilitating humanitarian coordination. Multi-organisational partnerships such as the Sierra Leone Information Service (SLIS), managed by the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) and OCHA, and the Data Exchange Platform for the Horn of Africa (DEPHA), which brings together UN, donor, NGO and government representatives, combine mapping, database support and risk analysis to help coordinate the reconstruction and development initiatives operating on the ground. Such partnerships are most effective when developed before an emergency erupts and nurtured through involvement in data collection, information product design and dissemination throughout all phases of a crisis.

Local Institutions

Because the primary responsibility for humanitarian relief lies with national and local authorities, these groups should not only have partnership but ownership of information projects.

When planning operations, humanitarians should consider how local institutions might be involved in information management. When appropriate, information managers should use local capacities where they exist, involve the local governments and organisations at an early stage and transfer information management tasks after the disaster has been resolved as a way to ensure the smooth transfer of information systems to local hands. This will yield better and more sustainable results than externally financed "got at it alone" approaches.

Field-based Web sites have been particularly successful at establishing local partnerships. For example, Save the Children's, *Assistance Georgia* site uses and exchanges data and information directly with government institutions, such as the Georgia Ministry of Refugees and the Georgia Department of Statistics, and grants them space on their Web site. In some cases, however, involving the local government in information projects is not so straightforward. In some countries, government may have limited authority over its territory or have a policy of using information against its populations

The Media

Humanitarian information managers have a responsibility for feeding information back to the populations they serve, including where to find food and medical relief, which NGOs operate in their towns and why.

To better communicate with beneficiaries, some services, such as IRIN, translate reports into local languages and publish them in the local press. Other organisations, such as the BBC Trust, Internews, the Institute for War and Peace Reporting and Media Action International are currently are building local media capacity by training local journalists in countries in transition, such as Afghanistan, as a way of improving access to free and independent reporting on the ground.

Best Practices for Developing and Maintaining Partnerships

Maximize resources by establishing partnerships. Recognize that data and information are collected and managed by a variety of actors including national governments, UN agencies, NGOs, the private sector and research institutions and that the contributions of these providers are crucial.

Pre-establish inter-agency agreements and relationships at the national and local levels. Relationships should be established with appropriate agencies at the national level in high-risk prior to an emergency situation. Maintain an ongoing process of personal interaction to create partnerships for information management and exchange.

Promote trust and transparency through linkages. Use distributed networks and neutral portal repositories to assist with information sharing, and promote linkages to avoid duplication of effort.

Engage local and national actors in information projects. Develop networks of local communities and national NGOs, civil society groups and the private sector and address the issue of local participation as part of overall emergency planning, monitoring and evaluation. Build and strengthen the national/local capacity in information management and exchange and promote the transfer and use of local knowledge.

Partnering with the media can be an effective way of communicating information to the affected population. Use local and international media outlets to inform the local population about humanitarian relief operations.

Maintaining Data and Information Quality

During the often fast-moving events of a humanitarian crisis it is easy for good practice in data collection and information integrity to be ignored in light of limited time and resources and the urgency of humanitarian needs.

In addition, field assessments and situation reports may contain contradictory or repetitive information or focus on a single sector – e.g. water, sanitation, logistics, security – using different definitions, assessment criteria and methodologies. Some locations and populations may be assessed repeatedly, while others may go unreported. Experience has shown that much of field reporting is anecdotal and in narrative form, rather than systematically organised and categorised as data. Integration of this information to obtain a comprehensive picture of the situation often becomes difficult, if not impossible.

The use of flawed or disorganised data leads to faulty decision-making, potentially at the expense of lives. Because of these operational risks, it is important to develop common approaches to data collection and information exchange. On a procedural level, this includes establishing defined terminology and standard operating procedures for activities, such as needs assessments and surveys, so that similar information can be easily compared across organisations. Applying technical standards means everything from using standard units of measure, to developing common identifiers for places and events, to employing common design elements and navigation schemes on related Web sites.

Adherence to such standards makes it easier to handle large volumes of information, avoids the need to re-invent the wheel with each new emergency and preserves quality control and institutional memory even with frequent turnover.

For example, the Rapid Village Assessment tool was created to standardise the collection of humanitarian needs data down to the village level. Using a standard survey form developed by the HCIC and NGOs in Kosovo, aid agencies, NGOs and KFOR troops were able to use a common template to gather the information across a variety of sectors. The data was then easily synthesised into a variety of reports, which were distributed to the humanitarian community online and on CD-ROM for use as baseline data. The RVA tool has since been standardised and implemented in a variety of crises.

Initiatives such as the Structured Humanitarian Assistance Reporting (SHARE) concept aims to establish standards for the use of information in the field. Jointly developed by members of the geographic information support team (GIST), an informal forum of geographic information specialists from humanitarian aid agencies, the SHARE approach aims to minimise disparities in information by organising data so that it can be pooled from a variety of sources, organized by location, time, source, sector and then compiled into databases. Included in the SHARE approach are the use of metadata (information about the information), and the development of p-codes. For example, using p-codes allowed GIS specialists to pinpoint overlooked villages during flooding in Mozambique, and to determine the origin of returnees during refugee registration in Sierra Leone.

The use of common identifiers for natural disasters is being implemented as part of the GLIDE (Global Identifier Number) project. Developed by a partnership of the Centre for Research on Epidemiology of Disasters (CRED), the Asian Disaster Reduction Centre (ADRC) and ReliefWeb, GLIDE promotes the use of unique alphanumeric codes to identify natural disasters so that organisations collecting disaster information can easily share this information. Introduced in January 2002, GLIDE is currently being used by CRED, ADRC, ReliefWeb, the Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO), the US Agency for International Development (USAID) and the World Bank's Disaster Management Facility.

To preserve information and data integrity, it is vital to maintain a strong sense of professional ethics at every stage of system design and implementation. Though ad-hoc ethical guidelines exist within individual organisations, the creation of a humanitarian information code of ethics adopted at both individual and institutional levels would preserve data integrity in data collection, database design, GIS mapping, analysis and dissemination, and establish minimum standards for metadata, intellectual property, privacy and respect for human rights.

Best Practices for Maintaining Data and Information Quality

Follow generally accepted standards for information exchange, such as the Structured Humanitarian Assistance Reporting (SHARE) standard, to promote data sourcing, dating and geo-referencing to allow cartographic presentation and geographic information system (GIS) analysis.

Define ambiguous terminology. Clarify commonly misused terms such as "affected" or "refugee" to avoid misinterpretation by different users and audiences.

Coordinate methodologies for surveys and needs assessments. These should be coordinated and designed to avoid bias, and should include training and documentation. Assessment methodologies and criteria should be explicitly stated.

Use metadata. Develop metadata documentation for each new product. Create metadata dictionaries and handover procedures as part of a standard, transparent documentation process.

The Importance of Preparedness

Information flow during a crisis can be crippled by lack of time, few resources, isolated decision-making, limited information sources and disrupted communication among actors, making it difficult to gather and process accurate data in a timely way. Moreover, information gathered during an emergency tends to be reactive and behind the curve. So one of the most important aspects of humanitarian information management and exchange is preparation, or as one participant quipped, "an ounce of preparedness is worth a pound of response."

At the core of emergency information preparation is the collection of baseline data, particularly for high-risk areas. Because some datasets are common to all emergencies information managers can collect most of this data, such as population figures, location and condition of roads and emergency contact lists, as part of preparedness procedures.

It is also important that information managers focus on forming institutional relationships, at national and local levels, before a crisis erupts. In this way, both national and international actors can collaborate on collecting and sharing key indicators, and support national and regional coordination initiatives. Preparation also includes planning for sustainability, so information managers should define an exit strategy.

Finally, implementing standards and using metadata preserves quality control and organisational learning and avoids the need to start from scratch with each emergency.

The events during the flooding in Mozambique are a testament to the benefits of preparedness. Once Mozambique was designated a high-risk area for drought and flooding in different provinces in 1997, government institutions collaborated with international agencies including USAID's Famine and Early Warning System (FEWS), the World Food Programme (WFP) and OCHA to collect early warning statistics including climate forecasts, seasonal conditions population figures and other key indicators. In addition, the UN established a working group of government and international agencies to analyse Mozambique's vulnerability, create flood contingency plans and pre-position food aid.

In February 2000 Mozambique experienced the most dramatic flooding in its modern history. Though the level of preparedness was not perfect, preparation paid off. Having pre-established content, mechanisms and relationships, it was possible for both national and international information systems to improve the efficiency of the relief efforts and enhance coordination among government and international organisations.

However, information managers should be aware of local sensitivities and possible political and economic impacts before publishing preparedness and contingency plans. Publicising potential hazards may create problems and, in some cases, make these scenarios self-fulfilling. For this reason, governments are sometimes reluctant to engage in contingency planning.

Best Practices for Preparedness

Maintain preparedness "toolboxes" for online and offline distribution. These toolboxes provide guidelines and reference tools for the rapid-deployment of HICs or the establishment of Web sites, intranets and databases under a variety of field conditions. Toolboxes should include data standards, operating procedures, training materials, database templates and manuals.

Develop surge capacities for rapid deployment. Maintain rosters of experienced information professionals, equipment caches and training programmes.

Preserve institutional operational memory. Define and adhere to sound data and information management policies and techniques for handling large volumes of information. Document datasets with metadata. Maintain quality control and preserve organisational learning to avoid starting from scratch with each new emergency.

Define an exit strategy. Develop a clear, phase-out strategy, including transitioning to development activities and creating archiving systems to maintain access by current and future stakeholders after the project is closed.

The Power and Limitations of Technology

Recent advancements in the sophistication, speed and portability of information technology, satellite communications and GIS mapping tools make up-to-the minute information analysis, verification, extraction, and distribution both possible and powerful. The proliferation of Internet technologies and evolution of the Web have allowed humanitarians to quickly and cost-effectively reach a global audience, from both headquarters and, increasingly, from the field.

Frequently, competing and proprietary formats make file-sharing cumbersome, a lack of standards make data collection inefficient and disparities in connectivity and technical ability make information inaccessible to those who need it most. Achieving humanitarian objectives via technology is therefore not a question of hardware and software, but rather of access, and appropriateness.

One of the greatest challenges to information systems, particularly in the field, is access. Even the most robust databases and powerful search engines are worthless if users are unable to retrieve the information in or through them. Information system designers should consider explicit and proactive efforts for making systems relevant and easy to use, particularly in remote areas. To this end, information managers should forego using the latest systems and tools in favor of technologies that enable the broadest possible use and reach. For example, in order to reach their core audience of aid practitioners in Africa, IRIN distributed its reports via an e-mail service that "pushed" their articles to users' inboxes.

The Internet, though powerful, is not always the best distribution channel, particularly in remote areas. While field missions may not always have Internet, satellite or cellular connections, most do have access to laptops. For this reason, information specialists in the field should distribute their data products including databases, encyclopedias, maps and assessments on CD-ROM. This achieves a wide distribution at little marginal cost.

On the other hand, the Internet is effective at feeding information from the field back to headquarters. Wherever possible, information products should be developed in Internet-ready formats. For example, though the Sierra Leone Encyclopedia was distributed to field officers on CD-ROM, it was developed in a Web-ready format so that it could be immediately transferred to the Internet for use at UN, agency and NGO headquarters.

A second key issue is inter-operability, or the importance of making information available through a variety of means in a variety of formats. Again, this is particularly important in field situations where high-end software programmes may be costly or unavailable. Though Symposium participants refrained from making specific technology recommendations, they supported the use of of-the-shelf software packages and standard file exchange protocols, such as XML, and asked that emerging technologies be one of the subjects addressed at a future symposium.

Information managers should also work toward bridging the technological divide by promoting the exchange of knowledge and skills between local and international actors. When designing information systems, managers should deliberately use technical solutions that conform to the sophistication of the local infrastructure and should train national staff in these technologies to ensure that these systems are not abandoned once missions are over.

Finally, information managers, practitioners and decision-makers should know and understand technology's limits. Technology is a means to an end, and not an end itself. Therefore, it cannot substitute for ideas, insight or human ingenuity, and is only as powerful as the people that apply it.

Best Practices for Using Technology in Humanitarian Information Systems

Use appropriate technology. Ensure that field information systems reach the broadest possible audience. Create software systems that are flexible enough to respond to data providers and field requirements.

Be aware of the limitations of technology (both inherent and as related to availability). For example, keep in mind that the Internet, while powerful, is not a panacea and can be ineffective as a distribution channel to and from remote areas or within many developing nation capitals. Consider making data products, particularly databases, available via e-mail, CD-ROM and for local download. However use the Internet to capture data entry from the field.

Use open data formats and inter-operable technologies. Use commercial, off-the-shelf technology and create all information products using open data formats and inter-operable technologies.

Promote awareness and training. Conduct technology-training sessions for non-technical humanitarian staff, particularly national staff. Educate senior decision-makers in humanitarian organisations about the purpose, strengths and weaknesses of information management and exchange. Broaden participation in information projects among affected and at-risk populations. Recognize that local staff's ability to work with the technology is an important determinant of success.

Engaging the Private Sector and Academia

Humanitarian information systems have yet to tap into the full potential of the private sector and academia, particularly in the area of hardware and software development.

However, some significant private sector and academic initiatives have found humanitarian applications. For example, Microsoft is working with Mercy Corps and Save the Children to develop logistics tracking and needs assessment software packages for use with PDAs. Benetech, a Silicon Valley-based technology non-profit built the Martus Project (www.martus.org), an information storage and retrieval system that brings efficiency to the storage and retrieval of human rights violations to speed up the response to violations, and in some cases, prevent additional abuses.

In addition, ESRI, a California-based GIS and mapping software company, has developed the Geography Network (GeoNet), a global network of geographic information users and providers that enables the sharing of geographic information between data providers, service providers, and users around the world. Through the Geography Network, users can both access and post many types of geographic content including live maps and downloadable data. FAO is already using GeoNet with a community of experts around the world who need access to data to create maps of disasters.

Among academic institutions, the University of Georgia's Information Technology Outreach Services (ITOS), under contract with the GIST, is currently working with the Afghanistan Information Management Service (AIMS), The Sierra Leone Information System (SLIS) and the Data Platform for the Horn of Africa (DEPHA) to manage and host a data repository of critical high-memory graphics, satellite imagery and metadata files.

Cambridge-based aidcommunity.org (www.aidcommunity.org) allows aid workers in the field to access both the Web and each other and provides them with easy-to-read information packages they need during relief operations. For example, a team of environmental health specialists and a water engineer arrive in a flooded community to conduct a field assessment equipped with a satellite phone and a laptop. The water engineer requests a chapter from a handbook on boreholes in waterlogged areas, and aidcommunity.org sends it as a text e-mail with thumbnail diagrams to minimise file size. The environmental health worker searches aidcommunity.org and contacts someone who worked in the same community two years earlier for a description of survey techniques she used.

Best Practice for Engaging the Private Sector and Academia

Involve the private sector and academia. Consider the efficiencies of contracting technical functions to the private sector, especially local private interests, when cost-effective and appropriate. Encourage a constructive role for the private sector and academia by incorporating their expertise into preparedness and planning activities.

Resource Mobilisation

Though information management is increasingly recognised by practitioners as vital to the effectiveness of humanitarian assistance, the role of information projects in relief operations is still not adequately funded by donors.

Donors tend to view emergency information needs as ancillary to operational ones, and prefer to allocate resources toward direct assistance programmes. The scarcity of resources for information projects works against information exchange by feeding competition among organisations and NGOs and encouraging information exclusivity.

Organisations should therefore aim to include information projects in overall funding requests for assistance programmes, and should persuade donors, national governments and the private sector to invest in information preparedness and prevention. Information managers should aim to sustain their projects through external funding, long-term partnerships and the transfer of information activities to local and national institutions.

Mobilising support and resources also requires improved advocacy programmes that educate senior managers and decision-makers about the importance of humanitarian information and raise donor and media awareness about the concrete benefits of information to humanitarian action.

Best Practices for Resource Mobilisation

Mobilise adequate resources. Include funding for field-level information management and exchange systems and projects in the overall resourcing of assistance programmes.

RECOMMENDATIONS AND IMPLEMENTATION

In order to explore these issues address current and future challenges, Symposium participants adopted a set of principles, best practices, and recommendations for next steps in a Statement on Best Practices In Humanitarian Information Management and Exchange. Below is the text of the Statement as amended and adopted by Symposium participants.

Statement on Best Practices In Humanitarian Information Management and Exchange

Preamble

Interested practitioners in the field of information management, including government representatives and institutions, UN agencies, non-governmental organisations (NGOs), academia and the private sector, met to take stock of achievements in the humanitarian information management field, to identify future challenges and to agree on next steps.

Based on their collective experience, the participants endorsed this statement as a vision for the future and a prescription for action.

By endorsing this statement participants agreed to 1) share its contents with their respective organisations; 2) raise these issues with international institutions and actors for broader discussion and implementation; and 3) work with OCHA to follow up on its recommendations.

Overview

Timely and accurate information is recognised as integral to humanitarian action in both natural disasters and complex emergencies. The international humanitarian community's ability to collect, analyse, disseminate and act on key information is fundamental to effective response. Better information leading to improved response directly benefits affected populations. Over time, improved assessment of impacts and responses through better data collection and management contributes to a more complete global database on disaster impacts, leading to better risk assessment and targeting of prevention and preparedness activities.

The Symposium recognized that considerable progress has been made to date in developing information systems, tools and Web sites and in establishing standards for their use. In particular, participants acknowledged the ReliefWeb, Integrated Regional Information Network (IRIN) and the Humanitarian Information Center (HIC) models as successful examples of international and field-level activities and services that form a solid basis for future work. But much remains to be done to build upon these approaches and continue to meet the demands of decision-makers and other stakeholders.

Principles of Humanitarian Information Management and Exchange

The Symposium affirmed the fundamental principle that the purpose of humanitarian assistance is to assist affected and at-risk people. Information management and exchange should reflect this humanitarian imperative and promote more effective humanitarian action.

Symposium participants also identified the following operational principles to guide information management and exchange activities:

Accessibility. Humanitarian information and data should be made accessible to all humanitarian actors by applying easy-to-use formats and by translating information into common or local languages when necessary. Information and data for humanitarian purposes should be made widely available through a variety of online and offline distribution channels including the media.

Inclusiveness. Information management and exchange should be based on a system of collaboration, partnership and sharing with a high degree of participation and ownership by multiple stakeholders, especially representatives of the affected population.

Inter-operability. All sharable data and information should be made available in formats that can be easily retrieved, shared and used by humanitarian organisations.

Accountability. Users must be able to evaluate the reliability and credibility of data and information by knowing its source. Information providers should be responsible to their partners and stakeholders for the content they publish and disseminate.

Verifiability. Information should be accurate, consistent and based on sound methodologies, validated by external sources, and analysed within the proper contextual framework.

Relevance. Information should be practical, flexible, responsive, and driven by operational needs in support of decision-making throughout all phases of a crisis.

Objectivity. Information managers should consult a variety of sources when collecting and analysing information so as to provide varied and balanced perspectives for addressing problems and recommending solutions.

Humanity. Information should never be used to distort, to mislead or to cause harm to affected or at-risk populations and should respect the dignity of victims.

Timeliness. Humanitarian information should be collected, analysed and disseminated efficiently, and must be kept current.

Sustainability. Humanitarian information and data should be preserved, catalogued and archived, so that it can be retrieved for future use, such as for preparedness, analysis, lessons learned and evaluation.

Key Issues
In support of these principles, Symposium participants highlighted a number of key themes to be considered when developing and implementing humanitarian information management and exchange systems.

1) User Requirements

The Symposium emphasized that information management systems should meet the clearly defined needs of users and decision-makers, and aim to reduce the effects of information overload.

2) Quality of Data and Information
To be useful, data and information must be relevant, accurate and timely. Ensuring quality requires the development of, and adherence to, standards for information collection, exchange, security, attribution and use. In addition, it is vital to maintain a strong sense of professional ethics at every stage of information system design and implementation, including such elements as independence and impartiality, in pursuit of humanitarian action.

3) Technology
Technology is a powerful enabler. Technology should not, however, undermine, distort or overshadow content. Achieving humanitarian objectives by using technology is not primarily a question of hardware and software, but rather of cost-effectiveness and appropriateness for achieving desired humanitarian outcomes. Information system designers should consider explicit and proactive efforts for making systems relevant and easy to use, particularly in remote areas. This includes bridging the technological divide by building capacity, promoting the exchange of knowledge and skills between local and international actors and making information available through a variety of means in a variety of formats. Human judgment, rather than technology, is the basis for operational decisions.

4) Partnerships
Successful information management systems encourage openness, inclusiveness and sharing. This strengthens relations, trust and coordination among multiple stakeholders. Multiple information systems, including Web sites and databases, operating at global, regional and local levels, create the potential for an unprecedented degree of cooperation between organisations and people at the field level, between the field and headquarters and between the international and local communities. Partnering with the media can be an effective way of communicating information to the affected population.

5) Preparedness
One of the most important aspects of humanitarian information management and exchange is preparation. Information-related efforts that are incrementally resourced and initiated only as emergency situations unfold tend to remain behind the curve and reactive. This leads to a failure to provide timely information that is accurate and contextual. Preparedness measures such as base data preparation for high-risk areas, national-level capacity building and the formation of institutional relationships prior to deployment enable information management and exchange systems to effectively support assistance efforts once an emergency begins. Preparation also includes planning for sustainability and/or exit strategies.

Best Practices
The following is a set of best practices derived from the principles and themes summarised above and identified as integral to the future success of humanitarian information

management and exchange. In complex emergencies and natural disasters, the humanitarian community should:

Define user needs and emphasise data sets and formats that directly support decision-making at the field level. Identify user groups, conduct user requirement analysis, inventory information resources inventory and define core information products based on user input. Develop and implement information products on operationally relevant themes, such as the location and condition of the affected population, "who is doing what, where?" and factors affecting access to affected populations. Use templates such as the Rapid Village Assessment (RVA) tool to speed data collection. Create maps to effectively communicate information to decision-makers.

Collect and analyse base data and information before and throughout an emergency. Gather, organise and archive data and information on operationally relevant themes for high-risk areas in preparation for emergencies. Maintain and enhance data sets during emergency responses. Document and archive data so that it is easily accessible for future use.

Maintain and promote data and information standards. Follow generally accepted standards for information exchange, such as the Structured Humanitarian Assistance Reporting (SHARE) standard to promote data sourcing, dating and geo-referencing. The SHARE standard facilitates integration of data from multiple sources and enhances verifiability, assessment, analysis and accountability. Geo-referencing data during collection allows cartographic presentation and geographic information system (GIS) analysis. Create metadata catalogues as part of a standard documentation process with handover procedures.

Maximize resources by expanding partnerships. Recognise that data and information are collected and managed by a variety of actors including national governments, UN agencies, NGOs, the private sector and research institutions and that the contributions of these providers are crucial. Pre-establish inter-agency agreements and relationships at the national and local levels. Establish an ongoing process of personal interaction to create partnerships for information management and exchange. Use distributed networks and neutral portal repositories to assist with information sharing and promote linkages to avoid duplication of effort.

Engage local and national actors in information projects. Develop networks of local communities and national NGOs, civil society groups and the private sector and address the issue of local participation as part of overall emergency planning, monitoring and evaluation. Build and strengthen the national/local capacity in information management and exchange and promote the transfer and use of local knowledge.

Maintain preparedness "toolboxes" for online and offline distribution. These toolboxes provide guidelines and reference tools for the rapid-deployment of HICs or the establishment of Web sites and databases under a variety of field conditions. Toolboxes should include data standards, operating procedures, training materials, database templates and manuals.

Define an exit strategy. Develop a clear phase-out strategy, including transitioning to development activities and creating archiving systems to maintain access by current and future stakeholders after the project is closed.

Preserve institutional operational memory. Define and adhere to sound data and information management policies and techniques for handling large volumes of information. Document datasets with metadata. Maintain quality control and organisational learning to avoid the need to start from scratch with each emergency and to maintain quality of information services during emergencies.

Establish field-based HICs according to identified operational and decision-making demand. Design them as open-access physical locations, incorporate existing capacities, systems and information management activities. Serve as a neutral broker of humanitarian information, providing value-added products and beneficial services to the field-based humanitarian community. Encourage broad participation from local, national and international actors to facilitate and support humanitarian response activities. Form partnerships with specialized agencies and sector experts to conduct sectoral surveys and analyses.

Use appropriate technology. Ensure that field information systems reach the broadest possible audience. Be aware of the limitations of technology (both inherent and as related to availability). For example, keep in mind that the Internet, while powerful, is not a panacea and can be ineffective as a distribution channel to and from remote areas. Consider making data products, particularly databases, available via e-mail, CD-ROM and for local download. Recognize that local staff's ability to work with the technology is an important determinant of success. Technology should be easy to use and be accompanied by training for local staff.

Use open data formats and inter-operable technologies. Use commercial, off-the-shelf technology and create all information products using open data formats and inter-operable technologies.

Promote awareness and training. Conduct technology-training sessions for non-technical humanitarian staff, particularly national staff. Educate senior decision-makers in humanitarian organisations about the purpose, strengths and weaknesses of information management and exchange. Broaden participation in information projects among affected and at-risk populations.

Involve the private sector. Consider the efficiencies of contracting information management and exchange functions to the private sector, especially local private interests, when cost-effective and appropriate. Encourage a constructive role for the private sector by incorporating private-sector expertise into preparedness and planning activities.

Mobilise adequate resources. Include funding for field-level information management and exchange systems and projects in the overall resourcing of assistance programmes.

Recommendations and Follow-Up Actions

Participants endorsed the above principles, themes and best practices and committed to working on resolving outstanding issues. To this end, Symposium participants agreed to work proactively within their respective organisations to promote recognition of, and investment in, information management practices to improve humanitarian action.

The Symposium participants recognized that necessary resources would need to be identified and raised to implement these recommendations and follow-up actions. Participants also emphasised the importance of mobilising resources to provide adequate funding for information management and exchange activities incorporating the results of the recommended actions.

The Symposium acknowledged OCHA's role as a focal point in the area of humanitarian information and recommended that a multi-stakeholder steering committee be established by OCHA to:

1) Draft specific guidelines for humanitarian information management and exchange;

2) Catalogue best practices through the ongoing development of lessons-learned case studies, project evaluations and the identification of appropriate technologies;

3) Establish working groups as needed, including representatives from recipient countries, to implement recommendations; and

4) Establish and announce an appropriate process for implementing these recommendations through consultation with stakeholders.

Specific areas to be addressed through this follow-up process include:

- **User requirements.** Explore the linkages between data, information and decision-making in critical areas, such as assessments, "who is doing what, where?" and other operational information, particularly in the field. Improve the exchange of data and information collected during natural disasters and complex emergencies for operational purposes as well as to strengthen the database on global disaster impacts over the long-term.

- **Quality of Information.** Develop and disseminate standards, ethical guidelines and codes of conduct to address issues of data quality and information integrity.

- **Technology.** Evaluate and report on successful applications of new and existing technologies. Identify technology partners and promote the dissemination of appropriate technology practices for varying end uses. Discuss the application of these technologies in a future forum.

- **Partnerships.** Strengthen the linkages among existing information systems. Improve relationships between these systems and their stakeholders including decision-makers at the field and headquarters level, as well as with the affected population. Establish public-private partnerships especially in the area of systems and tools development. Define the roles of sector specialists and the media.

- **Preparedness.** Promote the preparation of base data for high-risk areas. Calculate and disseminate risk assessments, and build national capacity and develop toolboxes for rapid mobilisation of HICs. Raise donor – and, where appropriate, media – awareness of the importance of information preparedness to humanitarian action.

- **Field-level coordination**. Improve field-level information coordination among multiple actors including the UN resident coordinator and UN country team, NGOs, academia, the affected population and other stakeholders. Facilitate OCHA's role as an information field focal point or partner. Evaluate and implement field-level information policies such as access and exit strategies.

Progress on these recommendations will be posted on ReliefWeb, submitted to the Inter-Agency Standing Committee (IASC) and will become the subject of the next symposium.

CONCLUSION

Data and information are powerful elements that, when shared and used appropriately, can improve humanitarian assistance in exponential ways. The faster humanitarian organisations are able to collect, retrieve, analyse and disseminate key information, the more effective the response and the greater the benefit to affected populations.

The innovations and accomplishments in humanitarian information over the past five years demonstrate that this is not merely a theory, but a trend that has begun to take hold. As highlighted by the Symposium presentations and discussions, there are a variety of information initiatives that successfully support humanitarian operations – from preparedness to relief to reconstruction – and are providing tangible results in affected communities around the world:

- **Preparedness.** By coordinating and collecting baseline data for regional hot spots, implementing standards, and building analytical tools, information management and exchange is improving the ability of both national and international actors to predict, plan and prepare for disasters and conflict;

- **Operational response.** By converting raw data into rich databases and dynamic maps, developing common procedures for surveys and needs assessments and designing data repositories with rapid retrieval search applications, humanitarian information systems are improving the operational effectiveness of humanitarian practitioners;

- **Capacity building.** By building information projects from the ground up, training local staff in technologies and partnering with government and local institutions, information managers are not only ensuring the sustainability of information systems but also empowering local communities to take information exchange into their own hands.

Though these initiatives have been bolstered by technology, particularly by the availability of powerful, cost-effective applications and distribution mechanisms, it is partnerships, human ingenuity and respect for humanitarian principles that give these programmes relevance and weight.

Despite such progress, the humanitarian information community still faces operational, institutional and strategic challenges that prevent information management and exchange from becoming fully integrated into relief programmes. Information practitioners grapple with information overload, incompatible technologies, non-standard datasets, lack of resources and competing information policies as part of their daily work. But they cannot address these issues alone. As the field of humanitarian information evolves, senior managers, decision-makers and policy officers working at organisational and strategic levels must ensure that the recommendations identified here are backed by enough support to turn ad hoc approaches into institutional imperatives with accepted standards, methodologies and practices. It is hoped that by creating a multi-stakeholder framework to help define future direction, the humanitarian information community is taking a first step toward providing a focused yet flexible foundation on which information can be used to achieve this change.

But perhaps the greatest challenge for this field is creating a culture of information sharing that promotes the free flow of data, information and ideas, facilitates informed decision-making and builds trust and commitment among stakeholders. More than a task for steering committees and working groups, it is a process that requires strong leadership, vision and investment. Information management is not a set of discreet tasks, but a process that underpins all aspects of humanitarian response and requires long-term institutional support and ample, sustained investment. Because of what's at stake in humanitarian operations, the consequences of not sharing information are too high to ignore.

ANNEX A – AGENDA

Symposium Agenda
Plenary Sessions February 7-8, 2002

Thursday, 7 February 2002

9:30 – 10:00	Opening and Welcome Keynote Address Speaker: Ms. Carolyn McAskie - OCHA/New York
10:00 – 11:15	**Panel Discussion 1:** What has been accomplished in the field of humanitarian information over the last five years and what key challenges remain? **Panelists:** Ms. Alta Haggarty – OCHA, ReliefWeb [198k] Mr. William Whelan (Ph.D) – USAID, FEWSNET [83k] Mr. Paul Mylrea – Reuters/AlertNet [188k] Ms. Joanne Clarke – OCHA, Integrated Regional Information Networks [2356k] **Moderator:** Mr. Simon Missiri (Ph.D) – International Federation of the Red Cross/Red Crescent Societies (IFRC)
11:35 – 12:50	**Panel Discussion 2:** What are the benefits and constraints for organisations to collect and share information in the field and what can be done to promote organisational buy-in to share this information? **Panelists:** Mr. Giorgio Sartori – UNDP/Somalia [2996k] Ms. Sophie Tchitchinadze – Save the Children/ GeorgiaWeb/Georgia [1109k] Mr. Getachew Diriba (Ph.D) – World Food Programmeme/Cameroon [1031k] Mr. Robert Turner – OCHA/Geneva **Moderator:** Mr. Ricardo Mena – UNDP/OCHA Latin America
12:50 – 14:15	LUNCH
14:15 – 15:00	**Presentation of Task Team A** Share best practices in the development of field based websites and make recommendations to strengthen field-based information exchange among humanitarian partners.

15:00 – 15:45	**Presentation of Task Team B** Investigate the use of new, emerging technologies and approaches, such as portal search engines, knowledge management gateways, etc. to enhance the exchange and retrieval of information .
15:45 – 16:05	COFFEE BREAK
16:05 – 16:50	**Presentation of Task Team C** Review lessons learned and evaluate database applications for field-based, cross sectoral information coordination.
16:50 – 17:35	**Presentation of Task Team D** Review lessons learned and evaluate field-based humanitarian information centres
17:35 – 18:15	**End of Day wrap-up by rapporteur**
18:15 – 20:00	RECEPTION - PALAIS DES NATIONS

Friday, 8 February 2002

9:00 – 9:20	**Review and Keynote Address** Speaker: Mr. Edward Girardet - Media Action International
9:20 – 10:40	**Panel Discussion 3:** How can simple common standards and practices enhance inter-operability of systems and the sharing of information? **Panelists:** Mr. Maxx Dilley (Ph.D) – Colombia University, International Research Institute for Climate Prediction Ms. Nan Buzzard – The Sphere Project Mr. Jean Yves Bouchardy (Ph.D) - UNHCR Dr. Debarati Guha-Sapir – Centre for Epidemiology of Disasters (CRED) Ms. Kathleen Miner – UNHCR and OCHA **Moderator:** Mr. Satoru Nishikawa - Asian Disaster Reduction Centre (ADRC)
10:40 – 11:00	COFFEE BREAK
11:00 – 12:15	**Panel Discussion 4:** How is information used for humanitarian coordination and strategic and operational decision-making?

Panelists:
Mr. Randolph Kent (Ph.D) - UN Somalia Resident Coordinator
Mr. Bill Garvelink - US Agency for International Development
Mr. Alan Matthews - UK Department for International Development
Mr. Brendan Gormley - Disasters Emergency Committee (DEC)

Moderator: Ms. Carolyn McAskie - OCHA/New York

12:30 – 14:00 LUNCH

14:00 – 15:30 **Presentation, discussion and adoption of the Statement**

15:30 – 16:00 **Closing remarks**

ANNEX B – PARTICIPANTS LIST

Symposium on Best Practices in Humanitarian Information Exchange
Plenary Session, 7-8 February 2002

Consolidated List of Participants

CHAIRMAN

Tsui Ed	Director OCHA New York

KEYNOTE SPEAKERS

McAskie Carolyn	UN Deputy Emergency Relief Coordinator, OCHA
Girardet Edward	Media Action International

RAPPORTEUR

Dilley Maxx	Columbia University - International Research Institute for Climate Prediction

SYMPOSIUM COORDINATOR

King Dennis	UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs

PANELISTS

Panel Discussions

1. What has been accomplished in the field of humanitarian information over the last five years and what key challenges remain?

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2. What are the benefits and constraints for organisations to collect and share information in the field and what can be done to promote organisational buy-in to share this information?

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3. How can simple common standards and practices enhance inter-operability of systems and the sharing of information?

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4. How is information used for humanitarian coordination and strategic and operational decision-making?

McAskie Carolyn (Moderator) UN Deputy Emergency Relief Coordinator, OCHA
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Matthews Alan Department for International Development (DFID)
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Canada	Norton Leslie, First Secretary Permanent Mission, Geneva
Denmark	Iversen H.E. Henrik Rée, Ambassador Michael Jensen - First Secretary Permanent Mission, Geneva
Finland	Raatikainen Hanne, Second Secretary Permanent Mission, Geneva
France	Duchêne, Hélène First Secretary Séverine Le-Guevel, stagiaire Permanent Mission, Geneva
Germany	Mr. Bittner, First Secretary Mr. Erben or Mr. Reiserer Permanent Mission, Geneva
Greece	Mrs. Gunaris, First Secretary Permanent Mission, Geneva
Iceland	Johannesson, H.E. Stefan Haukur Ambassador Davidsdottir Ingibjorg, First Secretary Permanent Mission, Geneva

Ireland	0'Brian Ciara, First Secretary Permanent Mission, Geneva
Italy	Vigo Paola, First Secretary Permanent Mission, Geneva
	Cutillo Alberto, First Secretary Permanent Mission, Geneva
Japan	Tomita Koji, First Secretary Permanent Mission, Geneva
	Morikawa Toru, First Secretary Permanent Mission, New York
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	Godefroy Marc, First Secretary Permanent Mission, Geneva
Norway	Endresen Astri, Emergency Officer Permanent Mission, Geneva
Netherlands	Eeywke Fabre First Secretary Permanent Mission, Geneva
Portugal	Alves Pedro, Attaché Permanent Mission, Geneva
Russian Federation	Gusyginia Julia, Third Secretary Permanent Mission, Geneva
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ANNEX C – KEYNOTE SPEECHES

Opening Address
Ms. Carolyn McAskie, Deputy Emergency Relief Coordinator
Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs
Thursday 7 February, 2002
Palais des Nations, Geneva

On behalf of OCHA, I should like to welcome you to Geneva and to this groundbreaking event. You are here today as leaders in the field of humanitarian information management. You may work for one of the United Nations agencies, an NGO, a government, the media or the private sector. Many of you have worked for more than one of these groups. Together, you bring a myriad of perspectives from which we hope to benefit.

In the last decade, advancements in information management and technology have come a long way, providing us with many new ways of improving our response to natural disasters and complex emergencies. Indeed, we have learned a lot -- in the last five years in particular -- from our experiences in establishing Humanitarian Information Centres in crises ranging from Kosovo to Sierra Leone or rapidly deploying information management and technology specialists in the initial response to crises, most notably in Mozambique and Afghanistan and recently in the DRC.

But these developments do not stem simply from the availability of modern technology. Rather they evolved in response to the increased expectations, among us and the public at large, that are generated by such technological advances. As television and satellite transmissions increasingly focus public attention on poverty and suffering through real time images of the victims of disaster and conflict across the globe, we face greater pressure to respond not within weeks, but within days or hours. Indeed, it is not uncommon for journalists to reach the scene of a disaster and start broadcasting before we do. At the same time, as more and more agencies, NGOs and governments have become involved in the delivery of humanitarian assistance, we have been forced to find ways to ensure that all actors can contribute in a coherent, coordinated and effective manner. To rise to these challenges, we must continually better our response in the area of information management.

There is no doubt that the technology to do so is at our disposal and we have made good use of it in many instances. But I would like to caution against the urge to overwhelm ourselves with the latest innovations simply because we can. We must be guided by what we need: simple and user-friendly technologies that allow us to begin operating the moment we hit the ground. Most of our colleagues beyond this room are lucky if they can operate their own VCR. If the tools we expect them to use to set up an office are more advanced than that, then they may be too complicated for our needs. Ultimately, even if the information we seek sits somewhere in a database, it is utterly useless if we do not *all* possess the same basic technical skills to retrieve it.

At the same time, we must not forget that the greatest impediment to our work is access. To that end, we must remain mindful of the need to identify cost-effective and simple technologies that work in the deep field. This may indeed be one of our greatest challenges.

Similarly, we must understand that technology alone is not the solution. Despite recent developments in artificial intelligence, computers and information tools cannot conduct field assessments and collect the information in which we are interested. Nor can they make life and death decisions. These tasks must – for the time being --still be carried out by human beings.

All too often, when a crisis erupts, valuable time is wasted gathering baseline information about an affected area, which is often already available on the Internet. Even more troubling are the instances in which our greatest challenge is not the *lack* of information but rather too much of it from too many, sometimes conflicting, sources -- making it difficult to discern the most critical and relevant data from the not so useful. Just as the uncoordinated arrival of relief supplies can clog a country's logistics and distribution system, the onslaught of unwanted, inappropriate and unpackaged information can impede decision-making and rapid response to an emergency.

These challenges highlight the need for more systematic ways to process and standardise information, as well as to begin information gathering and sharing on vulnerable countries well in advance of crises.

We each have a stake in these endeavors. We all need information to do our jobs well. Increasingly, OCHA has recognized the importance of information management as the fourth pillar of humanitarian coordination, together with response, policy development and advocacy. Without it, we simply can't coordinate effectively. The same goes for sectoral or donor coordination bodies. Equally, agencies, NGOs and other organisations need information to plan and implement their programmes. By sharing information, we all become aware of which humanitarian and funding needs are being met, or not, and of what new factors or developments need to be taken into consideration in our decision making, thus enabling us to better target our respective responses to the victims of disasters. Without this information, we run the risk of wasting scarce resources by unwittingly duplicating efforts or acting based on misinformation. At worst, we risk lives because important security information is not shared.

For concrete examples of the potential for effective inter-agency and coordinated information management, we need look no further than two of the most recent and serious crises we faced: Afghanistan and the Goma volcano in the DRC.

In the extremely complex operating environment of Afghanistan, existing information systems maintained by UNDP, FAO and various NGOs were enhanced to create one common information framework dealing with emergency as well as transitional issues -- demonstrating not only the potential effectiveness but the high level of inter-agency involvement in information sharing. At the opposite extreme is the response to the volcanic eruption in Goma -- a comparatively small, localized and short-lived disaster. In this case, OCHA, with the full support of its partners, was able to deploy -- at very little cost and relatively quickly – existing information management capacities to provide up-to-date information services to the agencies and organisations on the ground through a rudimentary, but effective, humanitarian information center.

That being said, the fact that information management is an essential determinant of the effectiveness of the delivery of humanitarian assistance is still not fully appreciated, nor for that matter funded, by donors. As a critical component of any modern organisation today, information management and technology must assume its rightful place in the United Nations as an essential and indispensable part of the international humanitarian response.

At the same time, we must also endeavor to think beyond the United Nations and the immediate context in which we work for new solutions. There remains great – and largely untapped – potential to work cooperatively with the private sector to address some of the pressing concerns I have outlined above and I hope that over the next few days you will explore ways to forge new partnerships in support of better information management.

Which brings us back to the purpose of this Symposium: to document the lessons learned and best practices from past and current information activities and chart a course for the future. We seek also to raise awareness about the range of information activities out there and increase appreciation within the United Nations and among its partners of the role of information in humanitarian coordination and operations.

To do so, we must -- through our work here and when we go back to our organisations -- use our influence with key decision makers to prioritise and invest in information activities. In doing so, we must strengthen existing and forge new partnerships with humanitarian actors, including UN agencies, NGOs, donors, governments of affected countries and the private sector.

Coupled with the latest and increasingly affordable technologies, information is a powerful tool. If used wisely, information management is perhaps the most important means by which we can improve our effectiveness. It underpins every aspect of our work from assessment to advocacy, from coordination to fund raising. Therefore, even small improvements in how we manage information can yield exponential dividends for the benefit of all. To this end, I wish you well in this unprecedented effort to define the best practices in information management and eagerly await your final conclusions.

Keynote Address
Edward Girardet, Founder
Media Action International
Friday 8 February 2002
Palais des Nations, Geneva

Independent media and information: a key component of international humanitarian assistance.

Ladies and Gentlemen:

It is indeed a great honour for me to be invited to give this keynote presentation and to discuss what I consider to be a crucial component of international humanitarian assistance. I note that most of the participants will be discussing more technical approaches with regard to the exchange of humanitarian information, so I shall focus on the role of the media in this domain.

If I may, I shall also speak for some of the specialised media groups (not represented here) involved in the dissemination of information to local populations caught up in humanitarian crises or conflict and post-conflict situations. These include highly professional organisations such as the BBC Trust in London, Internews in Washington, the Institute for War and Peace Reporting in London, the Hirdondelle Foundation just down the lake in Lausanne, and my own organisation - Media Action International - based here in Geneva.

At this point, I just wish to add that from own point of view, I regard the word "humanitarian" as including not just emergency relief but also longer-term approaches which need to be incorporated from the very start of any crisis. I also consider "humanitarian" to deal with issues such as human rights, civil society building, and so on.

Several years ago, I was in this very same room as a panellist at a conference to talk about media and information. At the time, I made the point that any organisation, whether UNHCR, UNICEF, WHO…or the MSFs and Oxfams of this world - that did not include information as a principal component of its international aid operations should not be in the business. Several participants took me to task on this. One said that in no way could the dissemination of information be considered as important as the distribution of food or medical relief.

I disagree. Even more so than before, I maintain that credible and independent information is a crucial and indispensable part of humanitarian assistance. Because without communicating with the very people you are seeking to help, you run the risk of seriously undermining what you are setting out to achieve. And yet it is extraordinary how many donors and aid organisations are still willing to spend millions of dollars on material relief and yet are reluctant to support information initiatives which seek to put across – to all concerned - explanations as to what these donors or agencies are doing, and why.

Crisis-affected populations, refugees, victims of war need to know how, when and where to receive food, or medical relief. They also need to know who all these organisations are and what they are up to. We may know what UNHCR, ICRC, ACF, or SCF stand for, but most people on the ground do not. This was clearly the case in Albania during the Kosovo crisis when the refugees suddenly found themselves confronted by hosts of NGOs but had little idea what these organisations were purporting to do.

Local populations have a right to know what is going on with regard to humanitarian operations. And this includes understanding the surge of all these TV and reporting teams that suddenly appear asking all sorts of questions with thrusting microphones but often with little sensitivity. And I say this as a journalist who has covered numerous crisis situations since the late 1970s.

Many agencies, however, often assume that they have a God-given right to provide aid when and where they like. They do not consider it a responsibility to have to explain their actions or whether their proposed operations are in fact needed. We have seen this in Somalia, Rwanda, Kosovo, and now in Afghanistan where an estimated 1000 NGOs are seeking to set up projects. Many, too, prefer to support the more media-friendly projects such as children's clinics or women's projects in easily accessible areas rather than the less popular psychiatric centres or sanitation projects that are so desperately needed.

This is not to say that children's clinics or women's projects are not required, but how many of these organisations are actually responding to profile or fund-raising purposes rather than genuine on-the-ground needs? And how many are actually coordinating their efforts so as not to have duplication? We have seen this before and we are seeing it again in Afghanistan. This is a waste of resources and quite frankly, an abuse of public support. And yet is the general public really aware of how much of their compassion is often being misdirected for the sake of publicity?

This is where independent local and international media focusing on humanitarian, post-conflict or recovery operations can help make a difference.

For one, they can help keep aid agencies informed as to what their counterparts are doing elsewhere in the country thus improving the coordination process. They can also help crisis-affected populations better understand what is going on. Transparency and accountability of humanitarian aid is not something that should only be destined to the international community. Why shouldn't local people have a say in what is happening to their country or where aid should be channelled?

A lot of these points may seem quite obvious to all of us. However, despite the efforts of specialised media organisations - such as the BBC Trust, the Institute for War and Peace Reporting, Internews or Media Action International - to promote and improve the quality of humanitarian information, it is still an uphill struggle. Many donors - and aid agencies - continue to fail to grasp the importance of independent information for crisis-affected populations.

Over the past several months, I have received numerous strategy papers regarding proposed humanitarian aid and recovery operations in Afghanistan. Yet not a single one considered support for local media or information humanitarian information as a significant component of these proposed strategies. In fact, most did not even mention media or information at all.

And even at the Tokyo conference, media and information were dealt with almost as an aside. And at least one leading donor dismissed media and information as not being one of its concerns, such as health. Yet information SHOULD be one of its concerns. How can one even consider dealing with the propagation of good heath practices without including information? Not to regard information as a concern is being irresponsible to all involved, the taxpayers, the aid agencies, and above all, the beneficiaries…

Unfortunately, such attitudes represent a serious weakness of the international aid system. It also smacks of an incredibly archaic if not ignorant approach still found among major organisations, including many departments within the UN system. All too often, information is still considered in the form of press releases. Or as something to be controlled by non-media specialists with little understanding of credible information as a useful – if not vital - communications tool.

It is time that information stops being regarded as a public relations exercise. It needs to become an integral part - with appropriate resources and authority - of every humanitarian field operation. And it is time to let media professionals do the job. Too many doctors, engineers or technicians with insufficient experience seek to manipulate what they consider to be information with little regard for those who actually need to receive it. They also have limited concepts of the enormous possibilities of what existing needs-based information or media approaches can achieve if produced and disseminated properly.

Recent conflicts and humanitarian crises have demonstrated again and again the need for credible information for disaster-affected populations. They have also demonstrated some unusual approaches toward the dissemination of information that can help both local and international aid agencies communicate in a more credible and effective manner with their beneficiaries.

The BBC Trust is currently producing humanitarian information programmes broadcast on the BBC World Service for Afghanistan in Pushto and Farsi. It is also seeking to help develop public broadcasting in Afghanistan with an emphasis on free and independent reporting. Internews is in the process of developing special radio and television programmes combining news and drama aimed at civil society building in Afghanistan.

Both the Institute for War and Peace Reporting and Media Action International are setting up training programmes for young Afghan journalists. We are also creating an independent Afghanistan Humanitarian and Recovery Report that will combine both on-the-job training for Afghan journalists as well as serve as independent watchdog of overall aid and peacekeeping operations. We hope that this will be able to work with other partners such as ReliefWeb and AlertNet.

What is needed more than anything else is for the international community, both donors and aid agencies, to recognize the importance of credible and independent information as a vital tool for keeping local appraised of what is going on. And I stress the words "credible" and "independent."

I would also like to emphasise that the focus needs to be on what is needed rather than what is not. Ineffective projects that cater to political or donor expedience should also be avoided. Certainly, there are situations, such as Cambodia, where it was justifiable to establish a UN radio station. I don't think this was the case for Kosovo where dozens of local radio stations already existed when the UN came in. Over two million dollars of taxpayers' funding were spent, or misspent, on the creation of a UN radio. It would have made far greater sense to use the resources available to support local media but with the production of specific UN programming distributed to these stations, possibly at prime times in return for operational grants, and thus achieve a broader audience outreach. The UN would have had the satisfaction of knowing that its message was getting out and that it was supporting local media as its investment for the future.

Investing in local media is crucial in any given humanitarian or conflict/post-conflict situation. Information should not be imposed from the outside but seen to be independent and, if possible, locally produced.

Similarly, I believe it makes little sense for countries like the United States to invest in a propaganda media, such as Radio Free Afghanistan, rather than support local media or existing international programming such as the BBC, VOA, Deutschewelle. All these broadcasters already have large Afghan audiences based on decades of credibility, so why should Afghans suddenly begin listening to a new station created to the tune of 27 million dollars? Such taxpayer dollars would be far better spent on the support of local and independent media.

Further, media support should be directed preferably toward professional and bona fide media organisations with the experience of operating in humanitarian crisis or conflict situations. Donors should not use front organisations for political purposes, particularly if this then reduces their credibility among the aid groups or the local populations on the ground. After all, the international community should be supporting as much as possible democratic free media that will provide credible, reliable and independent information not just for the duration of an emergency but also for the long-term. Again, one needs to focus on what is available, and what works.

One final point: while the development and dissemination of so-called needs-based information should become part and parcel of every aid operation, so should independent monitoring. Independent media groups working in conjunction with other organisations, such as human rights groups or specialized humanitarian oversight organisations are probably in the best position to assure a watchdog role of international aid and peacekeeping operations. Such monitoring cannot be assured by the UN - because the nature of the UN system does not allow truly open criticism with regard to member states. However, they can – and should - work together in partnership with such groups in order to assure the dissemination of such information to avoid abuses…that are already occurring on a growing scale in Afghanistan.

To conclude, I would like to stress that enormous – and often highly imaginative possibilities exist for the dissemination of reliable information to populations-in-need. Equally important, is the need for public service-oriented media, both local and international, to serve as an independent watchdog of what is basically a massive aid industry worth billions of dollars every year. On both levels, quality information can make a massive difference in the way humanitarian and recovery operations are carried out.

To be successful, however, such initiatives need to be developed in a coordinated and transparent manner. And as long as their independence and credibility is respected, such media initiatives should be conducted in collaboration with all concerned – the donors, the aid agencies, the media groups, and – quite clearly - the affected populations.

Perhaps one way of starting is for the donors to automatically commit a portion of their overall budgets for international humanitarian or recovery operations to the support of short-term and long-term media initiatives that not only inform those we are seeking to help but also monitor our efforts in doing so.

Thank You.

ANNEX D

PRESENTATION – TASK TEAM A

Share best practices in the development of field-based Web sites and make recommendations to strengthen field-based information exchange among humanitarian partners

Presenter: Toby Lanzer, Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA), The Russian Federation

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Though field-based Web sites were rare three years ago, they have since become essential components in information exchange. They are relatively inexpensive to create, they don't depend on a lot of infrastructure, are multi-disciplinary, can disseminate information faster than more "official" channels and often serve the relief-to-development continuum.

Main Recommendations

Based on the collective experience of Task Team A participants, humanitarian field-based Web sites should:

- Service the needs of the target audience including international and local organisations;
- Remain focused and simple;
- Link to existing systems in order not to duplicate efforts, and indicate the source of the information and include disclaimers to guard against inaccuracies on others' data; and
- Keep up with technology, though never prioritise technology over content.

Goals

The overriding objective of all field-based Web sites is to make the coordination of humanitarian assistance more effective. Within that objective, field-based Web sites should support the following goals:

- Facilitate humanitarian coordination
- Improve operations
- Inform decision-making
- Promote early warning

In addition, field-based Web sites are uniquely positioned to preserve institutional memory by constantly updating, retooling, and archiving information as emergencies evolve.

Principles
The working group decided that the principles that guide humanitarian action, in particular humanity, impartiality, neutrality, and independence, should be applied to information management and exchange, and of course field-based Web sites. Adherence to such principles would cover the need for 'reinventing the wheel' and developing others.

Content
Overall, the substance of field-based Web sites should be based on the needs of practitioners and decision-makers within the context of the specific crisis. There are, however, some common content pieces that should be a part of every field-based Web site including:

- Resource Centre, including a document library, map centre and, database
- Community Area, including a notice board, contact list, site map, and vacancies section
- Local Regulations, a list of local government regulations and procedures that may affect operations
- Support Services, for example UgandAid has a list of potential suppliers
- News, which is relevant to humanitarian action
- Links, to relevant and credible news and information sources

To make these sites most effective, Web site producers should avoid using heavy graphics. File sizes should be indicated so that users can decide whether or not to take the time needed to download information.

Standardisation
In order to handle the large volumes of data and information generated during a crisis, and to avoid having to re-invent the wheel every time an emergency erupts, field-based Web sites should follow a pre-established set of standards that guide:

- Procedures, including information collection methodologies, language, etc;
- Technology, including the use of hardware and software packages to ensure maximum inter-operability and development and maintenance by local staff;
- Data, including standards for ensuring data formats, content and quality; and
- Meta data, including pre-established and common standards for identifying and documenting data

Buy-in
Like other field-based information systems, Web sites are able to keep content fresh and balanced. To achieve support and buy-in from partners, it is important to involve partners

and stakeholders in the early conceptualisation and development of the Web site, and by promoting the site and "selling" the benefits of its products and services on a regular bases once the site has been established. Education and training can also enhance buy-in.

Sustainability
In order to be sustainable, field-based Web sites should define an exit strategy early on. Such a strategy might include duplicating or "mirroring" a site on a server outside of the host country, building in long-term partnerships and pursuing new and diverse sources of income.

Conclusions and required actions
Field-based Web sites are essential components of humanitarian operations. They should be simple, straightforward, and directly address the needs of a clearly defined target audience. However, in order to be successful and transferable across countries and crises, key institutions and partners should develop common policies governing the establishment and maintenance of field-based Web sites.

Questions and Answers

Q: If a small organisation is trying to set up a Web site, where should they go? Are there start-up packages?

A: Chris Szpak from Save the Children in Georgia explained that a Web site is only a mechanism for information sharing and dissemination that should be customized to each situation and therefore not require any central infrastructure.

A: Joanne Clark from IRIN reiterated this comment by suggesting that field-based Web sites are merely platforms, whose tools should be guided by the needs of the users.

Q: Should government Web sites be used for humanitarian purposes or should there be central Web sites?

A: Toby Lanzer stated that governments' involvement in field-based W eb sites should be sought, and that the aim of field-based Web sites should always be to enhance the coordination of response to humanitarian emergencies or natural disasters.

A: Joanne Clark from IRIN mentioned that when it is not possible to give this task to governments, field-based Web sites should consider long-term partners such as UNDP, so that even if the humanitarian relief community hands over the Web site, the material can still be collected in the future.

A: Ed Tsui, Symposium Chair and director of OCHA New York, emphasised that it is the role of governments to manage information during disasters and that for this reason, governments should not only have partnership but ownership of these projects.

PRESENTATION – Task Team B

Investigate the use of new, emerging technologies and approaches such as Internet portals, knowledge management gateways, large data and information repositories, search engines, Web-based interactive mapping, etc. to enhance the exchange and retrieval of information

Presenter: Helga Leifsdottir, International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies

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Issues/Themes

Incentives for information sharing:
- Data is power
- Mind set change
- Need to give information in order to get information
- Donor system encourages information exclusivity

Technology gap/accessibility
- Connectivity
- Availability of hardware and software at the field level
- Training is often lacking at the user end in the field

Ensuring data quality
- Garbage in means garbage out
- Need to maintain quality at all levels (collection to analysis to dissemination)

• Collect and store information accurately

Lack of agreed standards
• Two levels: technological and information exchange
• Technological: software, hardware
• Information exchange: no methodology or coordination

Integration and dissemination
Vast amounts of information are available, so technology needs to assist with the coordination of the information.

Lessons Learned

Standard interfaces
Moving to open data formats (shapefile, dbf), standard data interchange (XML) allow interoperability

Symptoms of poor data quality
• Lack of coordination of data acquisition lead to duplication and poor quality
• Lack of available baseline data in the field
• Need metadata (data currency, data scale)

The human dimension
• Technology is good, but need trust, transparency, nurturing relationships and personal contact
• Partnership managers needed
• Data quality can only be assured by human intervention

Challenges to large portals
• Volume of information- be selective, put time and effort into accurately classifying and filtering the information

Easy to use applications
The simpler and more focused the application, the more chance of success of the tool.

Link Internet to alternative technologies (radio and other communication means)

Principles
Information exchange is essential!

Apply humanitarian principles
• Information should save lives and protect the rights of the beneficiary
• In addition, information respect copyright, organisational rights, ownership of information, attribution of source, privacy, human rights

Information exchange should be based on
User needs
Inclusiveness (public, private, NGO, academia)
Ease of use

Transparency and trust
Technology tools should be standard

Use technology to ensure data validity
Technology is not the only solution!

Best Practices

Conduct user requirements analysis
The field workers
The beneficiaries

Develop flexible systems
Create software systems that are flexible enough to respond to data providers and field requirements
Minimise training requirements
Develop systems to manage complexity
Manage the volume of information with a database backed content management system
Allow data entry from the field via the Internet

Recommendations

To OCHA
1) Develop technical standards for information exchange

2) Develop unique identifiers for disasters

3) Develop an information code of conduct or code of ethics on information sharing between humanitarian NGOs, international organisations, and the UN in a framework of collaboration

General
- Store information in relational database management systems in a retrievable format
- Use the Internet for data input and validation live in the field
- Ask donors to create incentives to sharing
- Information transfer to include local government/organisations
- Transfer knowledge and technology to disaster areas
- Integrate the Internet with existing technologies (radio, fax, etc.)

PRESENTATION – Task Team C

Review lessons learned and evaluate database application for field-based cross-sectoral information coordination.

Presenter: Kathleen Miner, Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, Sierra Leone

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Information management systems and processes form a common foundation for matching needs with resources and coordinating multiple actors.

Whereas information technology is a platform, information management is a process that includes a combination of design, data collection, data entry, data integration and management, analysis, data dissemination and output.

Themes
The following themes permeate all aspects of information management.

- **Standards**. Common methodologies and technical specifications are an integral part of any data management system because standards allow integration and analysis among different sources. Standards also allow information managers to prepare ready-made systems and tools for response.

- **Information integrity.** In gathering information, it is important to maximise the level of quality and data integrity, and to be honest when data quality is in question.

- **Collaboration**. Coordinating humanitarian information among a lot of actors and across sectors helps to avoid overlap and gaps in operations.

- **Preparedness**. Information coordination at both general (or headquarters) and country levels can be used to better prepare for humanitarian emergencies.

  General. Forms of preparedness common to all crises include the need for standards, best practices and forms, adequate resources including both funding and surge capacity and both regional and global relationships.

Country. At a country level, preparedness means developing country-specific standards, such as naming conventions and geographic data standards; developing and maintaining baseline information related to the context of the problem; and building and strengthening local capacity and local relationships.

- **Response.** How can information management be fully integrated into response, so that practitioners can hit the ground running? Coordinating information gathering and analysis, support and the excitement out of the crisis. Coordination of information gathering and analysis.

- **Informed decision-making.** Coordinate assessments, many overlapping. Means to establish joint assessment, where the gaps are, integrate it and make it available.

- **Dissemination and information flow**. To be useful any information needs to be quickly and broadly communicated.

- **Sustainability**. To be sustainable, information management systems need to preserve data and information throughout the cycle, from the preparatory phase through the emergency response phase and after the emergency has subsided.

Lessons Learned: An ounce of preparedness is worth a pound of response.
Establishing information systems once a crises has begun becomes much more difficult because of:

- Less time, fewer resources, particularly staff
- Inevitable gaps and overlap in assessment
- Isolated decision-making. Decision-making becomes based on information collected by them and not by the whole community.
- Flawed data. Inaccurate data leads to flawed decision-making and irrelevant systems.
- Limited dissemination. In a crisis, results by individual agencies are less likely to be shared and sharing among actors.

Best Practices

- **Preparedness in Kosovo.**

In Kosovo, preparedness occurred as a bit of an accident. By early 1999, before the NATO bombing and resulting refugee crisis, information systems were already in place. The Humanitarian Community Information Center (HCIC) was fully operational, technically capable and regarded by its partners and users as a neutral service provider. Information managers immediately created a set of common standards and developed information products, such as the Rapid Village Assessment (RVA) tool and common shelter survey forms, and coordinated a needs assessment survey for one-quarter of the province. More than 140 humanitarian organisations followed the standards used the tools resulting in a more coordinated response once the crisis erupted. These tools are still in use today.

- **SUMA**

The SUMA (supply management system), developed by the Pan American Relief Organisation (PAHO), grew of lessons learned in natural disasters where the uncoordinated arrival of unsolicited supplies, donated by individuals, clog national and international relief and distribution systems. SUMA organizes these supplies into a single, coordinated system that catalogues and tracks these donations so that relief organisations could identify relief priorities. National and local actors are systematically trained in SUMA so that it can be sustained and managed locally.

Recommendations: Prepare, Share, Be Aware!

- Expect and support professional information management systems;
- Build information management into emergency preparedness procedures;
- Develop and promote data standards for every country;
- Develop and maintain baseline data, especially in peacetime;
- Strengthen country information management capacity to maintain information;
- Information management systems should be user-driven;
- Donors and agencies should make data sharing a requirement for their funding recipients and staff;
- Use HICs or similar information centres (such as government information centres) to support data coordination;
- Develop a data code of conduct, ensure the quality transparency and awareness; and
- Build in sustainability to ensure long-term management of and vision for information management systems.

Principles

Information management systems should be:

- User driven
- Timely
- Collaborative
- Effective
- Accessible
- Sustainable
- Transparent
- Verifiable and honest

Summary

Humanitarian information management is a process that gathers and analyses information for humanitarian goals. In order for information to be integrated into humanitarian operations, information managers should address the following key themes: preparedness, awareness of data limits and integrity in dealing with those limits, collaboration to pool together and share agency resources and sustainability.

Questions and comments

Q: What are some data standards and where can I find out more about them?

A : Standards include everything from country codes dialling codes, ZIP code, identifiers that distinguish between countries or among divisions within countries emergencies. New standards often had to be created in emergencies. In addition to standards in data coding, collecting and labelling, there are information standards, such as codes of conduct, early warning, what and how information should be shared. ReliefWeb has developed some standards for this.

A: Both types of standards are important: ethics, where data comes from and who shared with whom. For example when we at Mine Action receive information we are not familiar with it is useless to us. More detailed data standards are critical to sharing information. Particularly important are sectoral information and standards, including what sort of activities involved, what sectors are over- or under-subscribed.

A: It is difficult to achieve comparable standards especially on international levels (including world vulnerability reports, national level comparisons, natural hazards, vulnerability and impacts). Even if information is not analysed at a national level, it needs to be comparable at an international level.

Q: At what level are standards applied to analysis? To what extent are specialized practices by various agencies that are performing analysis?

A: In Kosovo, the HCIC created data standards not analysis, but provided technical support to those who performed detailed analysis, like GIS support because few people know how to manage this.

Q: Data without some explanation of what it is and where it comes from means nothing to humanitarian workers, so some kind of standard text explanation or documentation is important. But what about interpretation of the data ? Who makes the value judgment? This is important.

Q: What about information collected from non-traditional partners such as scientific, or local groups. Information collected from them is unique and often doesn't fit. Such information is often usable in a particular situation, but it doesn't survive. How do you rationalise and manage this?

A: Craig Williams, OCHA Eritrea: This is a very good point. This is the very reason this type of information is traditionally not used in humanitarian operations. Data standards are one platform for integrating different information, the other is GIS.

A: Tom Gettman, World Vision : I have a nervous stomach about fact that when a situation happens we cannot measure up. It takes us a long time just to prepare for inevitable emergencies, such as in the Palestinian occupied territories, but in sudden emergencies we are dead ducks. No matter how much preparation, it is never good enough. In emergencies we know how to run, but we need really good suggestions how to walk and understand of local communities. How to develop the tool kit to do this?

A: Ed Tsui, conference chair: Complexity and standards in the most relevant and also cost-effective way to go about information management.

PRESENTATION – TASK TEAM D

Review lessons learned and evaluate field-based HICs

Presenter: Shawn Messick, Vietnam Veterans for America Foundation

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Definition

A humanitarian information centre (HIC) is a physical meeting space, staffed by specialists, where humanitarian actors can go to get their questions addressed. Within the UN system, the stewardship of HICs rests with the United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA), the UN's coordinating body for humanitarian operations, which facilitates their creation. To be effective, HICs should be seen as reliable, trusted information sources that are integral parts of inter-agency coordination structure to be effective from the time that it arrives. More than just information clearinghouses, HICs should be service-based and provide value back to the data providers that supply it.

Guiding Principles

As a matter of principle, HICs should always:

- Serve operational needs in that they are practical, flexible, relevant, responsive and timely;

- Become integral parts of decision-making support including education, process and developing institutional capacity; and
- Be supported by general principles of accessibility (location, language, format, outreach), reliability, accuracy (consistency and context) and inter-operability.

Lessons learned

Institutional

- An HIC should be an integral part of the interagency coordination structure and directly serve the humanitarian community.
- There is a need for streamlined administrative procedures, because often HIC need to be set up very quickly.
- There is a need for transition/exit strategy, which often involves handover to other organisations or, when appropriate, the government.

Data Management

- Data preparedness is essential.
- Common data standards.
- GIS development requires strong leadership and teamwork.
- Metadata must be acquired up front.

Service

- HICs should include a feedback processes serving staff and management and should add value, not duplicate or replace what others are doing.
- Greater buy-in is achieved through collaboration on and local adaptation of information products.
- An HIC should serve as an interface between technical staff and non-technical users. Information specialists need to cut the jargon and break down the language barrier in order to communicate technical issues to non-technical persons.
- Develop and facilitate guidelines and standards for information handling

Best Practices

Design (How you make HICs work)

- Pre-establish agreements for data-sharing.
- Always collect and maintain baseline data HIC as central organisation that collect the info (everyone has to develop its own info).
- Build common metadata catalogue. While HICs do not collect the data, they do provide documentation, or metadata (the who, where, when the information was collected).
- Follow SHARE principles of information exchange.
- Facilitate data management, not replace or duplicate, but add value.
- HICs need to be configured to begin providing services and products from the start.
- Ensure that all organisations have equal access to the information, which includes using standard formats in order to go faster.
- HICs should be viewed as conceptual toolboxes collecting tools, principles and best practices.

Implementation

- Whenever possible, use and maximise existing national and local resources (staff)

- Engage in "data diplomacy" from the outset. Define public domain information at the outset. All info should be considered to be on the public domain, but the question of what is public and private info has to be clarified early-on
- Establish an archive and archive procedures early.
- Educate and sensitise users on HIC products
- HICs should be geared toward both operational and decision-making needs

Recommendations
Systemic

- Forge agreements between UN Agency principals on how to establish HICs on a timely basis from the outset.
- Integrate HICs into existing information management frameworks and available technical resources. HIC should not be replacing anything.
- Agree on data standards as a way of analysing information. Develop a toolbox of agreed-upon data standards and formats on behalf of the humanitarian community led by OCHA with collaboration from the humanitarian community.
- On behalf of the IASC, OCHA should maintain a roster of competent HIC practitioners who have diplomatic and technical skills to be able to move in this environment.
- Establish procedures for data acquisition to meet urgent, real needs, including national mapping agencies, commercial sources and UN agencies.
- Maintain files and establish a collection of resources on both concepts and methods on what has been done in HICs.

Procedural

- Market and promote HICs by bringing in all members of the humanitarian community, integrating HICs into appeals to support their funding, advocacy with partners on data sharing and exchange practices and the use of common formats.
- Build capacity and compatibility with national resources must be integral parts of the evolution of HICs to ensure an appropriate transition and exit strategy. Exit strategies might include training local staff in information management skills and how to apply them.
- Evaluate each HIC a few months after installation.
- HIC project managers should ensure that HIC products and services add value.
- Project manager should also ensure appropriate physical access as well as a culture of service to achieve as much interaction with as many interested people as possible and to develop a culture of accessibility and information sharing.

Comments and Questions

Q: Do panellists working in HICs have exit strategies

A: Some HICs had already set the possibility of transferring information gathered by HIC to government or other organisations.

Q: How do you deal with the issue of confidentiality of the information sources?

A: Each situation has to be analysed in a case by case. There are different styles of HICs according to needs.

Q: Should an HIC only be involved in data collecting, or should it advise donors?

A: HICs are supporting decision makers, nothing more. They do not have teams that go to collect info, but rather provide the facility for collecting and sharing information.

A: HICs also have to be useful for the local population.

Q: W hat kind of arrangements do we have to make to put HICs in place? What are the criteria that we should use in setting up HIC? The magnitude of the disaster or emergency plus the duration? We have to be convincing when we go ask money from donors.

ANNEX E

Abbreviations and Acronyms

ADRC	Asian Disaster Reduction Center
AIMS	Afghanistan Information Management Service
BBC	British Broadcasting Corporation
CRED	Center for Research on the Epidemiology of Disasters
DEPHA	Data Exchange Platform for the Horn of Africa
DRC	Democratic Republic of Congo
FAO	Food and Agriculture Organisation
FEWS	Famine Early Warning System (USAID)
GIS	Geographic Information Systems
GIST	Geographic Information Systems Team
GLIDE	
HCIC	Humanitarian Community Information Center
HIC	Humanitarian Information Center
ICRC	International Committee of the Red Cross
IFRC	International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies
IRIN	Integrated Response Information Network
ITOS	Information Technology Outreach Services (University of Georgia)
KFOR	Kosovo International Security Force
MSF	Médecins Sans Frontières
NGO	Non-Governmental Organisation
OCHA	Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs
OFDA	Office for Foreign Disaster Assistance (USAID)
PAHO	Pan American Health Organisation
PDA	Personal Digital Assistant
RVA	Rapid Village Assessment
SHARE	Structured Humanitarian Assistance Reporting
SLIS	Sierra Leone Information Service
SUMA	Supply Management
UN	United Nations
UNDP	United Nations Development Programme
UNHCR	United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees
UNICEF	United Nations Children's Fund

UNJLC	United Nations Joint Logistics Center
USAID	United States Agency for International Development
USIP	United States Institute of Peace
VOA	Voice of America
WFP	World Food Programme
WHO	World Health Organisation